

Tadoba's core forest offers visitors a glimpse at dozens of graceful herbivore species, including the elusive four-horned antelope (chausingha)—seen here with her days-old infant

Much like the camera traps along the safari trails that capture images of the felines, Waghoba too chooses a 'here-but-not-here' approach. "Zero impact is impossible but we ensure our carbon footprint is close to it," says Swanand. This earth-friendly ethos percolates all the 14 cottage-style rooms, each with its own reading nook and outdoor sit-out. Bespoke herbal bath products come in refillable glass pump bottles, dental kits comprise a wooden toothbrush and a vial of toothpaste tablets and two-litre jugs replace plastic water bottles. A tent card on the writing desk sports a QR code that can be scanned for the day's pre-set meals. The fare includes continental and Indian regional cuisine as well as breads and desserts made in-house. Low-energy LED lights speckle both the indoors and external pathways, all facing down to illuminate one's steps while keeping local wildlife undisturbed at night.

In all things, little and large, it is ultimately the environment that shines. No televisions, limited network, Wifi available only in common areas, and a strict policy against loud music mean true nature and wildlife lovers will find a haven of harmony. The outdoor swimming pool, guided nature walks, cycling tours, boat rides along the scenic Irai dam and the lounge's library of books, wildlife films and board games offer relaxing entertainment and family time.

Regret, I find, is surprisingly short-lived in this place. When darkness takes over, the sky counters by unfurling a tapestry of glittering stars. The silence of a retired day tunes into the music of chirping tree frogs, fox howls and rustling leaves. Where dismay turns so quickly into delight, what's not to love? ■

Website: https://www.waghobaecolodge.com/home
How to get there: Waghoba Eco Lodge is a 2.5-hour journey from Nagpur airport on the eight-lane NH-44 Nagpur-Hyderabad highway.
Tariff: Rs 15,000 to Rs 21,000 per night, including three meals.
Ideal time to visit: October to January is ideal for nature safaris. Bird migrations and the annual flowering season between March and April may be of interest for photographers.

HERE TO STAY

PLAN YOUR 2022 TRAVEL AROUND THESE FABULOUS NEW PROPERTIES

By Prachi Joshi



The Connaught, New Delhi. Its retro-chic bar is a popular watering hole in the city

The Connaught, New Delhi

The Connaught's design is influenced by the Georgian architecture of Delhi's Connaught Place. With tourist attractions and entertainment options at its doorstep, it's the ideal place to stay in the capital. Make sure you grab a signature cocktail at its art deco-themed bar, followed by poolside dinner. Even if temporary, it's nice to have a Lutyens address.
seleqtionshotels.com

Aramness, Gir

Opened in November this year, Aramness is one of very few uber luxury stays in Sasan Gir National Park. Its 18 spacious, double-storey *kothis* feature opulent furnishing, Kutchi motifs and a shaded